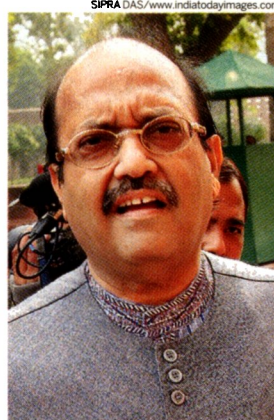


LUCKNOW | Getting Cold Feet

Speed thrills. It also kills. Uttar Pradesh chief minister's famed lightning reflexes while dealing with her political opponents suddenly seem to have deserted her. The latest episode is of the lodging of criminal cases against Samajwadi Party General Secretary Amar Singh over allegations of money laundering. When a furious Singh threatened to sue Mayawati for defamation, the state machinery reviewed the situation and clarified that the criminal cases were registered as a formality and would be transferred to the Kolkata Police for further investigations. The state Government was left red-faced when the main complainant in the case, Shiv Kant Tripathi, turned out to be a Mayawati fan. Earlier this year, Tripathi had organised a month-long yagna for Mayawati's ascent to the prime minister's post. What has further embarrassed the Government is the fact that Tripathi faces half-a-dozen criminal cases. This is not the only instance of the BSP



MAYAWATI (LEFT) AND AMAR SINGH



leader developing cold feet. Soon after taking over as chief minister in 2007, she had ordered inquiries into alleged scandals during Mulayam Singh's regime. But in many cases, the speedy trials boomeranged on the Government. It was evident that while proceeding against her opponents, the state Government had not done its homework well enough, allowing her opponents to go unscathed.

by Subhash Mishra

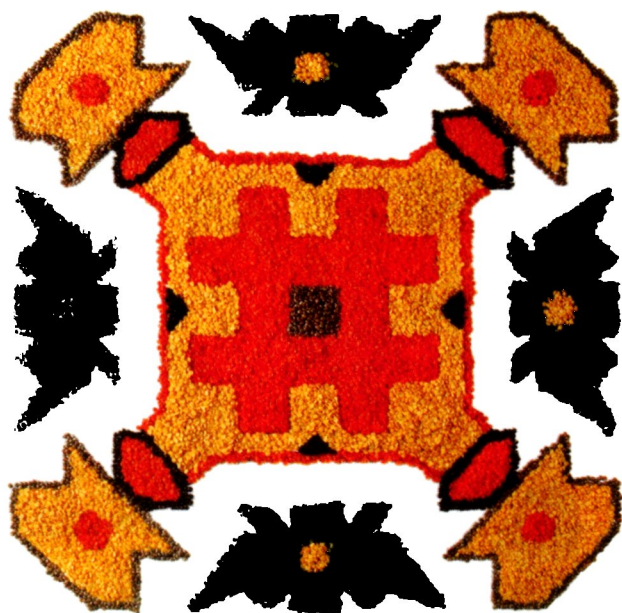
KERALA | Falling Out

The Popular Front of India (PFI), believed to be Kerala's most Islamist outfit, is fielding its leader Abdul Majeed Faizi for the Kannur Assembly seat for which a by-election is to be held on November 7, along with Ernakulam and Alappuzha. This move is likely to give jitters to the UDF, which had the PFI's support in the last Lok Sabha elections.

by M.G. Radhakrishnan

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